EL SALVADOR (17 September)

Heavy rains and flooding in early September all over the country and particularly in the central parts, including the district of Santo Tomas, near the capital, caused a number of victims and damage to infrastructure. By contrast, normal rains in the latter part of July and in August benefited the development of the 2002 first (main) maize crop currently being harvested. Some damage to the maize crops due to drought, however, is reported in isolated areas such as San Vicente and La Paz, in the northeast of the country. The damage has been induced by the short dry spell ("canicula") which occurs every year around mid-July. The situation has been aggravated for those small farmers who worked in coffee plantations to supplement their income and who have now lost their jobs as a result of the continuing crisis affecting the sector. Nevertheless, a maize output of some 610 000 tonnes is currently forecast for the year, a significant increase over the slightly above-average output collected in 2001. The rains also benefited fieldwork for planting of the important bean crop currently underway, and an early forecast points to a slight increase in production over last year's average level. Sowing of the 2002/03 sorghum crop started in August and intended plantings should be slightly above last year's below-average level. International food assistance to the 2001/02 drought-affected population, which was expected to finish in August, will continue for an additional few weeks.

